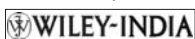


DigiPick of the month



This month's
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things. It would have been a billion-dollar industry!

On the other hand, if nothing of what they've predicted happens, there will be a little booing, and FIFI forgotten. It'll have been just another student project. But then, they made the grade, and the news—what more could one ask for?

WHY WOMEN DON'T GAME

They Want An Emotional Experience... Aargh!

Women make up less than 10 per cent of the gaming population. Why? In San Francisco, at the Sex in Video Games conference in early June, keynote speaker Sheri Ray said that it's not that women don't understand video games,

it's that video games don't understand women.

Ray has the credentials: she's been a game designer for the past 16 years, is a veteran of Sony Online Entertainment and the Cartoon Network, author of the book *Gender Inclusive Game Design: Expanding the Market*, and a long-time spokeswoman for women gamers.

Women or girl gamers need more than just action to stay involved, Ray said. She narrated an incident where a 13-year-old girl was good at a popular game, and instead of wanting to advance to higher levels, she got bored and quit the game. When Ray asked why, the girl said, "I pulled his heart out once, why do I need to do it again?"

Also part of the reason, Ray essentially says, is that women are portrayed as sex objects in games. The typical game heroine, as we know, has the word "sex" written all over her. She's something

like 38DD, and she doesn't wear much. But what about male characters, who are similarly exaggerated? Well, it's a fact that male and female characters in games are both portrayed as young, strong, and sexy, only female characters display the physical traits humans actually display "when they're ready for sex: partially open mouths, with large red lips, and heavy eyelids." And Ray says it's these "sex object" images that don't appeal to the average female gamer.

So to bring more women into games, then, how about "sexualising" the male characters as well? That won't cut it, according to Ray. She said, in effect, that women gamers aren't that excited about what the game looks like.

So what do women gamers look for in games? Tough question. As tough as "What do women want?"

Males reading the following are going to say, "Oh, please!"—Ray said the importance of the emotional experience can't be trivialised. And that games need to provide a way for women to have a deeper experience with the game characters.

Video game companies that want to get into the women-gaming market full-time will have to provide a way for players to become acquainted with their characters, Ray said. This includes allowing for an emotional attachment to develop.

Yes, we told you you'd go "Oh, please!" Emotional attachments in games? What's wrong with plain, good old action?

People Who Changed Computing

Jon "Protocol" Postel

Jonathan Postel is remembered as one of the powerhouses behind the early Internet. He edited or co-edited more than 2,500



Jon Postel

RFCs (Request For Comment). These RFCs were the foundation for the technical standards that govern the operation

of the Internet.

Postel's contributions began way back when the Internet "was the ARPANET." In 1969, Postel would manage the ARPANET's protocol numbers using scraps of paper. His contributions to the fields of computer communication protocols such as IP, TCP, UDP, Telnet, SMTP, and ICMP are monumental.

The man's love for computing began when he was studying towards his graduation at the University of California at Los Angeles. Postel was one of the members of the project that created UCLA's first (and then the only) Web site.

The Internet, quite simply, could not have been what it is without Jon Postel. For instance, it was he who suggested the dot notation for Internet addresses.

Postel was an easy-going, casual man: he was once ordered to put on his shoes before boarding a plane when he was to help the US Air Force with its computers. Amongst his interests were hiking and British whodunits.

In 1998, Postel received the International Telecommunication Union's prestigious Silver Medal in recognition of his contributions to the development of the global information infrastructure. He died the same year at 55.